

## Readings

### Meditation - From Psalm 86

Give ear, O Eternal, to my prayer, heed my plea for mercy. In my time of trouble I call You, for You will answer me. When pain and fatigue are my companions, let there be room in my heart for strength. When days and nights are filled with darkness, let the light of courage find its place. Help me to endure the suffering and dissolve the fear. Renew within me the calm spirit of trust and peace.

*Sickness is a sort of early old age; it teaches us a diffidence in our earthly state. – Alexander Pope*

When we are sick our virtues and our vices are in abeyance. –  
Vauvenargues

### Illness

Many of you know that I was on medical leave recently. I had this idea in my head, silly me, that I would go through major surgery, take a couple of weeks to start feeling better, and then spend the rest of my medical leave as a relaxing vacation. Things did not go according to plan.

However, I did learn some things during that time. And the things that touched me the most were the ones that are similar to the experience of many of my residents here. I had the honor and challenge of going through what many of you have known for a long time.

Often, when folks first move in here, they encounter one of the toughest spiritual and cultural trials. In our society, so much of our worth and value as a person is based on what we do. Through work, achievements, career, and even hobbies, we gain a sense of value and importance. We contribute to our world and we feel like we count. Even after retirement, there are many ways we can keep busy, active, and contributing. But what happens when failing physical or mental health does not allow for such productivity?

People come in here and often tell me that they feel worthless. They are no longer working and may not be participating in activities. Not only is there the stress of moving into a new place, there is the frustration of not feeling productive.

As a Chaplain, I tell them that while this is painful, it is a necessary spiritual lesson. When we come to understand that we are valued for who we are, rather than what we do, we have made a spiritual quantum leap.

Our ultimate worth is not based on doing. Just the fact that we are, that we exist, – that is enough. It's a tough lesson when we have learned otherwise all our lives.

Now this is something that I know. And in the past I have had this lesson drilled into me. Yet I was able to experience it again at a deeper level. During my recovery, I felt awful. I had no energy. I couldn't do much of anything – and certainly being productive was not much of a possibility. And I thought of my residents and how it is for many of you. The energy to be busy and work and achieve just isn't there anymore.

But to go even one step deeper, there wasn't even the energy to use the force of my personality. In the past, even if I was ill, I could still be charming, or caring, or witty and entertaining. I could be wise or helpful or funny. Somehow, I felt like I could rally some admirable part of my personality and use that. So even if I wasn't doing much, I could gain some feelings of value just from the strength of certain characteristics.

Not so this time. And I took comfort when I thought of some of you. I know that many of you have been powerful, lively, charismatic, funny, intelligent, insightful, compassionate, extraordinary people in your day. And your families will tell me about the days gone by, when you were at the top of your game. But now, for some of you, there just isn't the health or energy to be fully yourself. You can't rely on getting value from your current achievements and you can't even rally your old personality. You are living proof that you are important, lovable, and worthy – without any extras. No work. No productivity. None of the old powerful personality. And yet, you are loved and valued.

It is both freeing and humbling to learn that our worth is not based on what we do or even who we are. It is a given, just because we are. Even the first chapter in the Bible reminds us of this basic truth. We are valuable because we are made in the image and likeness of God.

*Genesis 1:27 God created human beings; God created them godlike, reflecting God's nature. God created them male and female.*

Along with not having the energy to be productive, I found some other things that some of you will recognize. I found that often I was too tired or in too much pain to talk and visit with people. Folks would come to see me or call on the phone, and I just didn't have it in me to talk to them. I was reminded of all the times I have gone into someone's room to pay a Chaplaincy visit and the individual would not want to talk to me. And I thought, "Oh, this is how it is when you can't even visit." My old social training would tell me I was being rude, and the part of my body that hurt just didn't even care. I didn't visit, because I couldn't visit.

In the same vein, I found that I had trouble doing the things I should have been doing to help my health. Many of you have heard this phrase, I was “non-compliant with cares!” The doctor or the nurse would tell me that I should eat 3 times a day. I should be disciplined and force myself. I would feel better. And I tried. I tried as hard as I could. And I could not do it.

Now I am a disciplined person. I take pride in doing the things that I need to do and not just letting my whims rule me. But in this case, I just flat out could not do what was asked. Even though I wanted to. And I thought of the times I have heard of a resident being non-compliant. And I realized that sometimes being non-compliant is not because a resident just doesn’t want to do what he or she has been told to do. Sometimes, they just flat out can’t. There is not enough energy or there is too much pain.

Even praying was hard. All of my carefully cultivated spiritual practices and religious disciplines went out the window. I wanted to feel close to God. Yet it takes energy to pray. Often all I could do was “Oh God, help. Amen.” Or “Oh God, when will this end?”

How often have I sat with residents who have told me that they don’t have a prayer life, or that they do not read their Bibles or meditation books. I came to understand at a deeper level that it isn’t because they don’t care or have lost faith. It may very well be because they don’t have the “umph” to pray. And at those times we have to trust that God still holds us. That’s all we can do. And the Bible tells us that God understands.

*Psalm 31:7*

*I will rejoice and be glad in Your lovingkindness, because You have seen my affliction; You have known the troubles of my soul.*

There were two other lessons I took from my time of convalescence. This particular one surprised me. When people came to visit me, I found that I had almost nothing to bring to the conversation. All I had to talk about was my body and what it was doing or what my latest health issues were. Before my illness, I had prided myself on being a good conversationalist. I usually had some grasp on current events and could talk about what was going on in the world or locally. I could tell stories or engage in theological dialog or raise interesting questions. And I used to be a great listener. So even if I didn’t say much, people felt heard and valued. But the longer I was ill, the smaller my world became. And when people came to see me, I had no new topics or information to give them. Only the news about my health.

There is an old stereotype about the elderly and the infirm only wanting to talk about their maladies. The image is of someone talking on

and on about their aches and pains and getting some enjoyment out of reciting all of their physical complaints. And it is likely that there are people like that.

But I can now tell you from experience that this is not always the case. Sometimes, when our health is compromised and we do not have the energy to interact much with the outside world, we have nothing else to bring in our visits. I would find that I wanted to talk and connect. I wanted to be a part of the conversation. But my news and stories were limited. I brought what I could. But all I had was the latest on my health. And it didn't take long to find that I was boring even myself! I was stuck with desperately wanting to connect with other people, and having very little at my disposal to bring to the conversation.

It was maddening and embarrassing. And I promised myself that I would not be so quick to stereotype someone if he or she only talked about ailments and treatments. That may be all someone has to offer. Jesus tells us in a parable that even when all we have to offer is a tiny amount, it is enough.

Mark 12:41-44

*Jesus sat down opposite the place where the offerings were put and watched the crowd putting their money into the temple treasury. Many rich people threw in large amounts. But a poor widow came and put in two very small copper coins worth only a fraction of a penny. Calling his disciples to him, Jesus said, "I tell you the truth, this poor widow has put more into the treasury than all the others. They all gave out of their wealth; but she, out of her poverty, put in everything--all she had to live on."*

This last lesson I want to direct particularly to our volunteers and family members. One of the things that touched me the most while I was ill was the care and attention of others. The people who came to visit me, the phone calls, the cards, - they meant the world to me.

I believe that I was sustained by the love of other people. For at least 6 weeks I had trouble eating. I felt nauseous and could not take food in. I grew weaker and weaker. But what kept me going was the care of other people. A card today. A visit the next. Maybe a phone call or two. And I knew, even in those moments, that the attention given to me was what was sustaining me.

I had no idea that this reaching out was so vital. Of course we all like attention and we all enjoy visits from family and friends. But this was different. This was my food. This was my sustenance. When I felt physically awful, the kind attention helped me forget for a time. When I felt lonely, or unlovable, a visit reminded me that people do care. When I just

didn't have the energy or will to keep trying and when I wanted to just give up, it was other people who encouraged me and gave me hope. And all that time, I kept remembering our visitors here. I thought that if these calls and visits meant so much to me, how much more would it mean to my residents. I remembered Jesus' words in praising his true disciples:

*Matthew 25:36*

*I was sick and you visited me.*

Working with you people has given me great comfort. While I was ill, I thought of you. It was not just "thinking about work." I thought of the trials you have gone through, the resilience you have shown, and the mercy of God that is evident in your lives. While I was recovering, I found that I could relate to you in a number of new ways. My admiration for you has grown. I have taken encouragement from you and how you have handled your illnesses and setbacks. You have been a blessing and a comfort – just by being you and allowing me to be a part of your lives. You helped me in my time of convalescence. Thank you.

Amen and Amen.